



Feasibility as a Parameter

When comparative research on narrow specialist populations can and cannot be executed

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THE EVIDENCE IS MY OWN FAILED STUDY

334,976

panel members screened

→ 20 eligible

→ 4 usable

Six per hundred thousand. I did not set out to study this. The constraint arrived as a result.



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ELEMENT 1 · RESEARCH TOPIC AND IMPORTANCE

Comparative research has a requirement it never states as one

To compare a phenomenon across countries you must reach the same population in every country, at the same time, with an instrument that means the same thing in each place.

WHEN THE POPULATION IS GENERAL

The requirement is demanding but routine. Effort and money convert into responses at a rate that differs by country and is always positive, always improvable.

A FIELDWORK PROBLEM

WHEN THE POPULATION IS RARE

Conversion is governed by arithmetic fixed before the first contact. That arithmetic does not add across borders. It compounds, and in one direction only.

A DESIGN PARAMETER

A design that is marginal in one country is not four times harder in four. It can be structurally impossible in four while remaining marginal in each one separately.



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ELEMENT 1 · RESEARCH TOPIC AND IMPORTANCE

The gap, and the question

THE TOPIC

Reaching a narrow specialist professional population in several national frames at once.

THE RECEIVED WISDOM

Sampling difficulty is an execution problem. It belongs to budget and local partners, and it appears in print as a limitation paragraph.

THE GAP

Nobody has asked what happens when the population is rare. The quantities that decide it are observable before fielding, and they compound across frames.

THE RESEARCH QUESTION

Under what conditions is a comparative multi-country design on a narrow specialist population feasible at all, and where must a survey give way to another method?

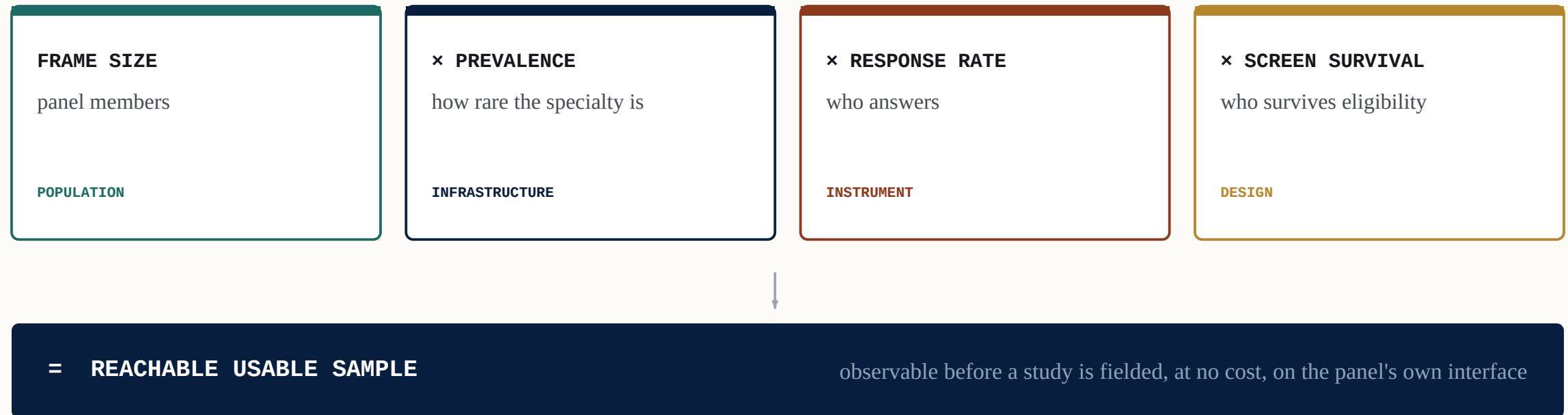


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ELEMENT 2 · STUDY MODEL AND HYPOTHESES

The model: four terms, four different levels

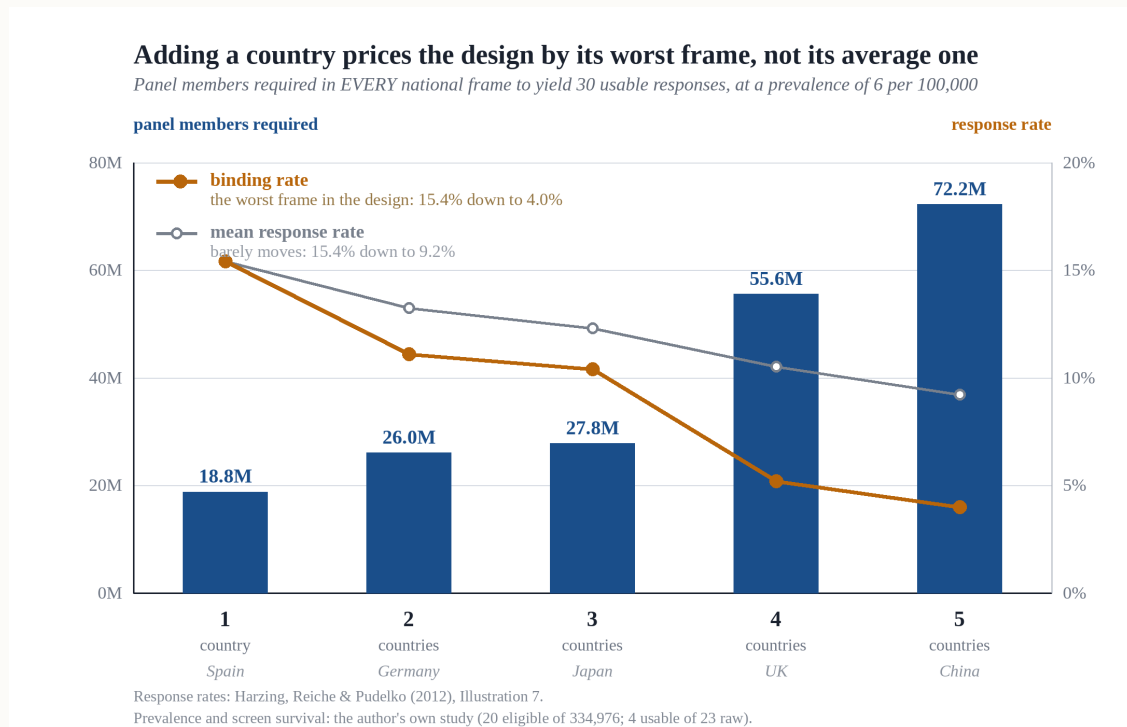
Reachable usable sample is a product, not a sum. Each term is decided at a different level, and attributing a failed frame to the country assigns to one level what another produced.





2 ELEMENT 2 · STUDY MODEL AND HYPOTHESES

The result that makes this a paper and not a complaint



ADD FOUR COUNTRIES

Mean response rate

15.4% → 9.2%

barely moves

Panel needed in EACH

18.8M → 72.2M

a factor of four

The design is priced by its worst frame, not its average one. Reporting an overall response rate reports the wrong statistic.



Five hypotheses

EACH TAKES ITS LOGIC FROM ONE OF THIS WEEK'S FOUR PAPERS

H1

Joint feasibility is set by the least feasible frame, not the mean. Adding a country can only weakly decrease it.

ANALYTIC · THE STRUCTURE OF A CONJUNCTION

H2

Specialist prevalence on a panel is higher inside the panel provider's home region.

RUGMAN & VERBEKE (2004)

H3

Studies described as cross-national achieve regionally concentrated coverage, more so as the population narrows.

LOPEZ, KUNDU & CIRAVEGNA (2009)

H4

Mode explains more variance in response than country does.

MEYER, LI & SCHOTTER (2020)

H5

Standardization is negatively associated with response, worst in the frames that already bind.

ZENG ET AL. (2023)



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ELEMENT 3 · JUSTIFICATION OF HYPOTHESES

H1 · A comparison is a conjunction, not an average

To say a relationship differs between Spain and China is to assert something about Spain and something about China. The assertion fails if either component fails.

AN AVERAGE CANNOT SATISFY A CONJUNCTION

A design with one excellent frame and one hopeless frame has a respectable mean and no comparison. The requirement is set by the minimum.

Because a set's minimum can only fall or stay level when an element is added, every additional country weakly worsens the design and no additional country can improve it.

Breadth is treated in comparative work as a virtue. It is purchased at a price that rises faster than the count of frames. A design covering more countries has not become more ambitious. It has become more fragile.



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ELEMENT 3 · JUSTIFICATION OF HYPOTHESES

H2 and H3 · A research panel is a firm

Rugman and Verbeke showed that firms called global are home-region bound, because firm-specific advantages transfer within a region cheaply and across regions only by being rebuilt. Lopez, Kundu and Ciravegna found the same gap in ventures called born global.

A commercial research panel is a firm. It recruits through professional associations, employment platforms, advertising markets and payment rails, each denser and cheaper inside the region where the provider originated.



WHY IT BITES HARDER FOR SPECIALISTS

A consumer panel is built by broad advertising anywhere. A panel of experienced auditors is built through professional bodies whose reach is national by construction.

AND WHY THE SAMPLE COLLAPSES

Set a global target, accept what arrives, and the result is formally multinational and substantively regional, with no decision ever taken to that effect.



3

ELEMENT 3 · JUSTIFICATION OF HYPOTHESES

H4 and H5 · Level of analysis, and the price of equivalence

H4 · MODE OVER COUNTRY

Response is the outcome of an encounter between a person and a request. Whether it arrives by telephone from a human being or by email from a platform is a property of the instrument, not of the country.

Mode changes the cost of refusing. Country changes only the disposition toward it.

THE ONE DATUM

Harzing's 47% in Korea was telephone. It exceeds the entire country spread in the same project by about five times. One observation is not evidence. It is why this is worth testing.

H5 · CONTROL AGAINST COORDINATION

Zeng and colleagues separate control, a standard imposed from the centre, from coordination, the alignment of units that keep discretion. The two trade off.

Equivalence needs an identical instrument. Response needs adaptation of length, channel, sponsorship and register. They pull the same instrument in opposite directions.

A strong frame can afford the loss. A weak frame had no margin, and under H1 the weak frames bind the design.



4 ELEMENT 4 · DATA COLLECTION PLAN

What gets measured, and why it can be measured at all

Panel providers expose an audience-configuration interface that returns an estimated reachable count once screening criteria are entered, before any commitment and at no cost. That is what makes feasibility a parameter rather than a limitation.

UNIT OF ANALYSIS	One occupation, on one panel provider, in one national frame
THE MATRIX	6+ occupations × 8+ national frames × 3+ providers ≈ 144 cells
PROVIDERS CHOSEN TO VARY	On home region, deliberately. H2 is unidentifiable otherwise
THE VALIDATING CASE	My own study. A model that cannot reproduce 334,976 → 20 → 4 is rejected

NO DATA HAVE BEEN COLLECTED FOR THIS PROJECT. THIS IS THE DESIGN, NOT A RESULT.



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ELEMENT 5 · EMPIRICAL ANALYSIS PLAN

Two different kinds of claim, two different treatments

H1 · ANALYTIC

Established by demonstration and probed by sensitivity analysis across the plausible range of prevalence, response and screen survival, reporting the region of the parameter space where a comparative design stays viable.

The claim is about the structure of a conjunction. It would not be made more true by a p-value, and reporting one would present a deductive result as an empirical one.

H2 – H5 · INFERENCE

Hierarchical linear models. Cells nested in national frames, frames nested in regions, random intercepts at frame and provider level.

The nesting is not a convenience. It is the structure Meyer and colleagues argue must be modelled, and ignoring it attributes to countries the variance that belongs to providers.

H5 IS SUPPORTED ONLY BY THE INTERACTION, NOT THE MAIN EFFECT



What this model does not claim

Prevalence is held constant across countries

It almost certainly is not. No cross-national prevalence data for these populations exists, which is why obtaining it is the contribution rather than an assumption.

The response rates come from one study

One instrument, one period. Treating them as a general country characteristic would commit the level-of-analysis error the paper itself identifies.

Rates are treated as independent

They are not. Frames within a region share institutional conditions and will correlate.

Panel estimates are vendor-supplied and unaudited

They are the same numbers researchers already rely on, so this adds no new exposure, but estimated against achieved is a validation step not yet in the design.



THE CONTRIBUTION

A parameter is estimated before a design. A limitation is confessed after it fails.

Comparative international business has treated who can be reached as a matter of execution. For general populations that is harmless. For narrow specialist populations it is not, because the arithmetic compounds across frames in one direction and is decided by the weakest frame rather than the average one.

The quantities are observable before a study is fielded. Making them part of the design, rather than part of the confession, is a small change in practice and a substantial change in what the field can claim to have compared.

AND THE SECOND IMPLICATION

Where the arithmetic rules out a survey it does not rule out the study. Twenty reachable participants are a failed survey and a well-powered phenomenological one.

THE THRESHOLD IS LOCATABLE IN ADVANCE